

TPM Academy — Tech Setup

Last updated: 2026-05-13 (rev 5)

Practical setup guide for participants and facilitators. Cover pre-academy setup once; refer back week-by-week as new tools come into play.

Audience

- **Participants:** read sections 1–3 before Week 1. Skim section 4 (week-by-week additions) the Friday before each new week.
- **Facilitators:** verify section 5 (pre-flight checklist) before each week. Section 6 covers fallback procedures when tooling fails.

1. Hardware & connectivity (pre-academy)

Requirement	Minimum	Recommended
Laptop	Modern dual-core, 8 GB RAM, 256 GB	Quad-core+, 16 GB RAM
OS	macOS 12+, Windows 10+, Ubuntu 22.04+	Latest stable
Browser	Chrome / Edge / Firefox latest	Same
Internet	Reliable broadband	Wired or 5GHz Wi-Fi
Webcam + mic	Working for remote sessions	Headset preferred
Display	1 monitor, 1280×720+	1080p+; second monitor helpful

For remote cohorts: confirm video conferencing client installed (Zoom, Teams, or Meet — per academy delivery).

2. Accounts & access (pre-academy)

Confirm before Week 1 starts. Many of these need IT or admin time — start early.

2.1 Generative AI tool access

Every participant needs **at least two** of:

- **Claude** (Anthropic) — free tier acceptable; paid preferred for longer context
- **ChatGPT** (OpenAI) — free tier acceptable; Plus preferred
- **Gemini / Copilot / equivalent** — for cross-tool comparison on Week 1 Day 1

For Week 1 Day 1's "Same Question, Three Models," the cohort collectively needs three different tools. Coordinate so triads have coverage.

2. Accounts & access — assessments

2.2 Skills / SkillIQ platform (pre- and post-assessments)

- Pre-assessment access: required before Week 1 (Product Management + Data Literacy)
- Post-assessment access: required for Week 8 Day 5
- Confirm participant logins work the week before academy begins

2. Accounts & access — Azure DevOps

2.3 Azure DevOps (Week 7 only)

Each triad needs one of:

- **Live ADO project** with create-work-item permissions (preferred — sandbox if possible)
- **Sandbox / training ADO instance** provisioned by IT
- **Read-only ADO access** with paper-template fallback (last resort)

If live ADO isn't available by Week 7 Day 1, fall back to the **paper-template** version of Day 2's lab — see section 6.

2. Accounts & access — document tooling

2.4 Document tooling

Each triad needs a shared workspace for collaborative editing:

- **Confluence / SharePoint / Google Docs / Notion** — pick one, use it consistently
- The 5 sibling artifacts (PRD/TCD/TMD/SEP/DP) live here
- Version history is required

2. Accounts & access — diagramming

2.5 Diagramming (Week 4–5)

For C4 diagrams (Wk 4 Day 3) and sequence diagrams (Wk 5 Day 4):

- **Whiteboard + paper** is fully sufficient — phone photos serve as the artifact
- **Miro / Lucidchart / Excalidraw / Figma** if digital is preferred
- **Mermaid** in the team's wiki for inline-in-doc diagrams

Don't over-invest in tooling here; the diagrams are thinking aids, not deliverables.

2. Accounts & access — communication

2.6 Communication

- A **cohort channel** (Slack / Teams) for async Q&A and resource sharing
- A **triad channel** per triad for daily coordination
- An **instructor DM thread** for individual coaching

3. Installations (pre-academy)

Most academy tools are browser-based. Two local installs help.

3.1 Reveal.js decks (already provided)

The daily decks live in `week-XX/presentations/day-XX-*.html`. They render directly in any modern browser:

```
File → Open → week-01/presentations/day-01-ai-fundamentals-prompting.html
```

No build step needed; Reveal.js loads from CDN. Press S for speaker notes / clock.

3. Installations (cont.)

3.2 Markdown editor (recommended)

For authoring PRDs, TCDs, etc., a markdown editor with live preview is helpful:

- **Obsidian** (free) — strong cross-doc linking
- **VS Code** + Markdown Preview Enhanced
- **Typora** (paid) — minimal interface

The labs reference markdown templates throughout; a comfortable editor pays off across all 8 weeks.

4. Week-by-week additions (Weeks 1–2)

Week 1 — Customer-Centric Foundations

- All AI tools confirmed and working
- Persona Validation Canvas, Pain-Point Severity Matrix, Problem Statement Template (printed or digital — see lab packets)

Week 2 — Strategic Design & Metrics

- Spreadsheet for Tier Sheet (Excel / Google Sheets / Numbers)
- Whiteboard or A2 paper for Journey Map Canvas (Day 5)
- One shared SaaS product for the Day 3 Heuristic Hunt (e.g. Trello) — same product cohort-wide

4. Week-by-week additions (Weeks 3–4)

Week 3 — Requirements Engineering & Mini-Capstone

- **AI tools off** for the week — honor system. Disable AI features in your editor.
- Markdown editor for PRD drafting
- Print or share digitally: PRD template (1 per triad)

Week 4 — Technical Architecture & Constraints

- AI tools restored
- Whiteboard / Miro / Lucidchart for C4 diagrams (Day 3)
- STRIDE Card handout (Day 2)

4. Week-by-week additions (Weeks 5–6)

Week 5 — Technical Infrastructure & Modeling

- AI tools, with validation discipline
- Diagramming tool for sequence diagrams (Day 4)
- Reference cards for HTTP status codes, REST methods (printed or bookmarked)

Week 6 — Stakeholder Alignment & Negotiation

- Power × Interest grid (paper or whiteboard)
- Stakeholder persona scripts (Day 5 simulation handouts) — instructor prepares ahead
- Surprise objection sets (Day 5) — instructor prepares ahead

4. Week-by-week additions (Weeks 7–8)

Week 7 — Agile Delivery & ADO Mastery

- **ADO access confirmed** (see 2.3 above)
- ADO Cheat Sheet handout (Day 2)
- VSM Canvas — large paper or whiteboard (Day 4)

Week 8 — AI Spec Development & Capstone

- AI tools, with validation discipline
- Capstone subject inputs gathered before Day 1 (interviews / data / docs — per triad)
- Presentation projector / screen sharing for Friday
- Post-assessment access confirmed (Skills / SkillIQ)

5. Facilitator pre-flight checklist (per week)

Run this checklist the **Friday before each week begins**:

- ☐ All participants have access to required tools (cross-check section 4)
- ☐ Print or digitally share the lab packet for Monday
- ☐ Pre-print handouts called out in each day's facilitator guide
- ☐ Confirm Week-specific instructor-prepared materials (Wk 6 stakeholder personas, Wk 7 ADO sandbox, etc.)
- ☐ Verify cohort channel and triad channels are live
- ☐ Verify the deck file for each day opens correctly in browser

5. Pre-flight — the two that bite

For **Week 7 specifically**: test ADO access with a sample work item by **Friday of Week 6**. Don't discover ADO issues at 09:00 Monday.

For **Week 8 specifically**: confirm the post-assessment platform is active and participants can log in by **Thursday of Week 7**.

6. Fallback procedures

When tools fail, the academy continues. Don't let tooling block learning.

If this fails	Do this
AI tool down for one cohort	Pair up with a triad whose tool works; document as a constraint in the provenance log
All AI tools down	The day's AI activity becomes a paper exercise : triads write the prompt, predict the output, then review when AI returns
ADO unavailable Week 7	Run Day 2 as " ADO concepts on paper " — same 4-level hierarchy, same field discipline, captured in markdown

6. Fallback procedures (cont.)

If this fails	Do this
Whiteboard / projector fails	Triads work on paper; phone photos are the artifact
Document workspace down	Local markdown files; sync when service returns
Pre/post-assessment platform down	Run paper version of the same instruments; submit when platform returns

The academy's content is the muscle, not the tool. Tooling failures are an inconvenience, not a blocker.

7. Common setup issues

Issue	Fix
AI tool rate-limits during heavy use	Distribute prompts across triad members' accounts; stagger API-heavy activities
ADO permission errors	IT ticket; meanwhile use sandbox or paper
Reveal.js deck won't render	Try a different browser; confirm internet for CDN; check console for blocked scripts
Markdown editor doesn't show tables	Switch to a CommonMark-compliant editor; preview in a browser
Network can't reach Slack/Teams	Triad channels via SMS / personal email as fallback

8. Pre-academy participant onboarding email (template)

Adapt and send 1 week before academy start:

Subject: TPM Academy – Setup Steps Before [Date]

Welcome. Before academy begins on [date], please confirm:

1. Hardware: laptop with webcam, modern browser, reliable internet
2. AI tools: at least two of Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini/Copilot – confirmed working
3. Pre-assessments: Product Management + Data Literacy submitted on the Skills platform [link]
4. Cohort channel: you've joined [Slack/Teams workspace link]
5. Pre-work (~3.5 hrs): complete the linked self-paced modules:
 - Exploring PM Philosophies and Frameworks [link]
 - Agile Methodologies primer [link]
 - Getting Started on Prompt Engineering [link]

Please reply with any access issues by [3 days before start].

Looking forward to Monday.

9. Resources

- Course README: README.md
- Glossary & acronyms: GLOSSARY.md
- Source outline: outline.pdf
- Daily decks: week-XX/presentations/day-XX-*.html
- Lab packets: week-XX/labs/day-XX-*.md
- Week overviews: week-XX/labs/README.md